

20260927 Mark 4:24-25 “The One Who Has”

Let us continue reading the Gospel of Mark today.

At the beginning of chapter 4, Jesus told the parable of the sower.

There were four places where the seed fell.

They were the path, rocky ground, among thorns, and good soil.

Jesus explains that the seed being sown is “the word.”

He said this about the good soil.

Mark 4:20 But those that were sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word and accept it and bear fruit, thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold.”

Those who were the good soil began by hearing. And because they accepted the word, they bore abundant fruit.

Those who did not accept it had heard it in the same way.

But they did not accept it.

And those who accepted it did not produce the seed themselves.

They heard the word sown by God and accepted it as something from God.

Because God is impartial, He gives His Word to everyone in the same way.

And how we receive it changes what happens afterward.

Following this parable of the sower, last week we heard the parable of the lampstand.

Here is a review of last week.

Where should we put the lamp: under a basket, or under a bed?

No, the lamp should be placed on a lampstand in the middle of the room.

When people spend a long time in darkness, their eyes gradually adjust,

and they become able to walk by relying on their own memories, experiences, and senses.

But before long, they even forget that they are in darkness.

That is also a way of life ruled by our sinful nature.

Such a way of life will leave us continually losing our way.

That is why Jesus tells us, “Look at the light of the Word.”

The path of the Word is sometimes difficult, and we may feel that we cannot move forward by our own thinking or calculations.

But when we follow that light, we are led to a wonderful place,

far beyond any outcome we might imagine in terms of our own gains and losses.

Are we now placing the Word on the lampstand and making it the center of our lives?
Are we letting that light shine into the depths of our hearts and into our homes?

If we examine our hearts now and realize that we have been hiding the light we have been given, that is already a great step forward.

No matter how many times we fail, let us bring out that light again and again and place the Word back at the center of our lives.

The light of the Word of Jesus Christ illuminates our lives and leads us into truly abundant life.

Concerning words such as these,

Mark 4:23 If anyone has ears to hear, let him hear."

that was what He said.

Today's passage is written immediately after this.

And here too, Jesus speaks about hearing the Word, the theme running throughout chapter 4.

Mark 4:24 And he said to them, "Pay attention to what you hear: with the measure you use, it will be measured to you, and still more will be added to you."

"Pay attention to what you hear."

To put the original wording briefly, it means, "Pay attention to what it is that you are hearing."

Jesus asks His listeners what their ears are receiving and how they are receiving it.

First, then, what are we to hear?

Jesus has already shown us what that is.

Mark 4:14 The sower sows the word.

Jesus is sowing the Word.

Mark 4:20 But those that were sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word and accept it and bear fruit, thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold."

So, when He says, "Pay attention to what you hear,"
what we are to hear is the Word of Jesus.

Now, let us consider, "Pay attention to what you hear."

How should we pay attention when we hear the Word?

When we read the Bible, we may think that we already know the passage well and skim over it.
Or we may be waiting for the words we want to hear.

Are we really listening to what Jesus is actually saying?

Are we opening the Bible only to find support for our own ideas?

And so on.

At such times, although we appear to be listening, we are not actually listening in the right way.

Each of us must be clearly conscious of this.

Am I listening “carefully” to the words of Scripture? Am I listening only on my own terms?

Am I merely nodding in agreement at a superficial level?

The Word is certainly difficult, but I think we can see the importance of engaging with it from the fact that Jesus Himself raises this issue again and again in this way.

Let us also “pay attention to what you hear.”

After that appeal, verse 24 introduces the subject of a measure.

It is an illustration of how we are to pay attention.

“With the measure you use, it will be measured to you.”

Certainly, when people use a scale, they judge the quantity by the reading on the scale they use.

An accurate scale measures correctly, so they can understand the quantity correctly.

But if the scale is incorrectly calibrated, they cannot measure the quantity correctly.

And they cannot correctly recognize how much it really is.

In other words, the kind of scale a person uses changes that person's judgment and understanding.

Jesus uses this relationship as an illustration when He speaks to His listeners.

Jesus does not directly say what is being placed on the scale,

but since the command immediately before this is, “Pay attention to what you hear,”

it is clear that this measure is also related to our attitude as we listen to the Word.

However, this does not mean that He is speaking of a quantitative standard,

such as understanding increasing in proportion to the time we spend reading the Bible.

We should understand it as meaning that we are to keep engaging with the Word with the right orientation.

What happens if we have the wrong scale?

If we listen to Jesus thinking that He is someone of little importance,

we may let His words pass us by as words of little importance too.

If we expect Him to defeat our enemies through military power, then even when Jesus speaks about

forgiveness,

we may think, “That is not what I want to hear.”

If we think Jesus is someone who always speaks only gentle words, His stern words will seem out of place.

If we listen thinking that He is one god among many, we will lose sight of the most important truth: that He is the absolute God.

In other words, because what is said differs from what a person expected, that person fails to receive the significance of the words being spoken.

That is what it means that “with the measure you use, it will be measured to you.”

It is given equally to everyone, but the amount each of us receives changes according to who we think Jesus is.

If we dismiss His words, thinking, “That is all they amount to,” we will miss what is being said.

If we seek only what we want to hear, we will fail to receive what Jesus is trying to communicate.

We judge Jesus within limits we have arbitrarily narrowed, and receive from the Word only what falls within those limits.

These are mistakes we may well make even without any ill intent.

Let us have a properly calibrated “scale.”

That is, Jesus is omniscient and omnipotent, the only God.

He is also the Creator of all things, and for that reason He truly loves each one of us.

We must hold firmly to this standard, first making this most important adjustment, and then listen to the Word.

But Jesus does not stop there; He says, “and still more will be added to you.”

When we encounter words that do not fit our own thinking,

we seek to listen further, asking, “Why does Jesus say this?”

As we listen in this way, we begin to be taught things beyond what we initially sought.

A person who wanted enemies to be defeated hears the words about loving enemies.

Even if these words are difficult to accept at first, as that person continues listening to Jesus, they may be taught a way of relating to others that they would never have imagined if they had thought only of the victory they wanted.

Jesus does not explain in detail here what will be added or how it will be added.

Presumably, it will vary from case to case and happen in stages.

But He promises us who listen, “and still more will be added to you.”

In other words, it will certainly happen.

Trusting that promise, I want us to avoid hearing the Word only through our present thoughts, and to listen to the words of Jesus carefully, thoughtfully, and expectantly.

That is what it means to “pay attention to what you hear.”

Mark 4:25 For to the one who has, more will be given, and from the one who has not, even what he has will be taken away.”

I would like us to pay attention to “for,” which comes at the end in the Japanese translation.

In verse 24, Jesus commanded us to pay attention to what we hear, and promised that it would be measured to each person according to that person's measure, and that still more would be added.

Verse 25 follows as the reason for this.

Mark 4:24 And he said to them, “Pay attention to what you hear: with the measure you use, it will be measured to you, and still more will be added to you.

Mark 4:25 For to the one who has, more will be given, and from the one who has not, even what he has will be taken away.”

This means that how we receive what we hear is connected to what we are given afterward and what we lose.

First, what does “the one who has” have?

Jesus has already said this in this chapter.

Mark 4:11 And he said to them, “To you has been given the secret of the kingdom of God, but for those outside everything is in parables,

In other words, the disciples “have been given” the secret of the kingdom of God.

Mark 4:20 But those that were sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word and accept it and bear fruit, thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold.”

And in verse 20, those who are the good soil hear and accept the Word and bear fruit.

In light of these words, I think we can read “has” in verse 25 in connection with “rightly receiving the Word given by Jesus.”

And that is the very secret of a way of life in which we make the Word something that concerns us personally.

Those who have this will come to know the depths of the Word more fully and will be able to turn their way of life in a better direction.

On the other hand, there are stern words in the latter half.

“From the one who has not, even what he has will be taken away.”

Mark does not write here, “what he thinks he has.”

Jesus certainly said that even what a person has will be taken away.

Returning to the parable of the sower, this is what is written about those along the path.

Mark 4:15 And these are the ones along the path, where the word is sown: when they hear, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word that is sown in them.

The same verb in the original language is used for “will be taken away” in verse 25 and “takes away” in verse 15.

Those along the path also heard the Word.

But the Word that had been sown was taken away.

Those who were the good soil likewise began by hearing, and they accepted the Word and bore fruit. In other words, both had experienced encountering the Word and hearing it.

And yet, it is taken away.

For example, I think we can consider a time when we hear about forgiveness.

We hear the Word telling us to forgive others,

and think, “Perhaps I too need to reconsider my relationship with this person.”

But then we reject that word, saying, “But that particular person is an exception.”

As we continue rejecting it in the same way,

even the initial sense that “the Word is speaking to me too” may begin to fade.

“Love your enemies.”

We may remember the words of Scripture.

Even so, we stop hearing those words as a call addressed to us.

Also, following the parable of the seed in Mark 4,

there is the example of the word we have heard being choked by the worries of life and the desire for wealth.

Words that seemed important when we heard them are put off amid our daily worries, and we no longer recall them when making decisions.

Eventually, we may find ourselves living just as we did before hearing those words.

The words remain as mere words, but they cease to work as a living word.

Jesus said, “Pay attention.”

At this very moment, we ourselves are being asked whether we merely imagine that we are listening to this Word.

Let us think about it once again.

Are we skimming over these words because we know them well?

Even though Jesus is urging us, do we ever avoid facing His words, thinking that there is no problem with us?

We truly need to examine this.

Here, let us look at this issue from a different angle.

As we read a little further in this chapter, this is what is written about Jesus and His disciples.

Mark 4:34 He did not speak to them without a parable, but privately to his own disciples he explained everything.

The disciples did not understand all the parables from the beginning.

But they asked Jesus about the parables they did not understand.

And Jesus explained them to His disciples.

Here, what was right was being “added” to them.

In their case, although they were immature in many ways, one thing we can say is that they loved Jesus dearly and had great expectations of Him. They must have respected Him from their hearts.

Certainly, they misjudged Him in various ways, thinking of Him as a political Messiah or as a very good “man.”

But what happened to them in the end? They came to know that Jesus, whom they had been measuring by their own scales, was One whose greatness was beyond all comparison with their interpretations.

In other words, although they made mistakes, they were facing in the right direction as they listened to the Word.

It was simply that the scales they had were too small.

They failed because of that, but because their direction was right, they were ultimately given something wonderful.

God is wonderful far beyond anything we can imagine.

Another mistake we need to be careful of is holding back from expecting too much of God.

Let us trust fully in God's power. At times, we think,

“God has done enough for me. Thank You.”

But is that really so?

God has prepared even better and more wonderful things for us.

If we continue walking toward God along the path of light,

He has prepared true blessedness and wonderful peace beyond anything we can imagine,
and overflowing grace beyond what we can receive.

As we read the Word carefully, we realize that beyond the stern words lies this wonderful place.

No matter how much we thank God or say thank You, His blessings never come to an end.

We must not make the mistake of ceasing to ask God either.

So we need to adjust our scales carefully and listen rightly to the Word.

Who is Jesus, and what is in His heart?

Let us first hold firmly to that. Then we begin to see something beyond our understanding.

Of course, because He is God, He cannot be contained within our own measure.

What do we do then?

We do not know, and we cannot fully understand, but with the conviction that the right answer is here,
we seek once more to hear the voice of Jesus. We keep listening and keep applying His words to our
lives.

This is what “the one who has” looks like.

From this conviction that Jesus is the One who is right, our understanding of the Word deepens, and
our faith deepens.

That changes the way we live and changes our lives. Let us cultivate this cycle that moves in the right
direction.